4.1 Overview

In college, many courses will ask you to put your writing skills to work, and this course is no different. Even short exercises, such as worksheets and discussion posts, can be stressful. Writing anxiety is real. Furthermore, you may have had negative experiences with writing activities in the past. Perhaps you got a low grade for a writing exercise that you were proud of. Maybe you received feedback that was less than polite. As you enter college, you will carry experiences (both positive and negative) that shaped your perspective on what it means to be a writer. This is a good time to recall the importance of growth mindset!

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The goal of this week is to help you see the value of writing in this course, future courses, and your potential for growth. Yes, writing can be challenging, and yes, you may carry the burdens of past negative experiences. The past is the past, but your path through this university setting has yet to be paved. You will, as you work with your classmates and instructors, realize your own potential. You have come this far, and by enhancing your writing skills, you can go further in this course and beyond.

Before beginning this week's exploration of the factors that lead to successful communication, take a moment to address some common misconceptions about writing.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 4.1.1: Misconceptions About Writing

1) Successful writers are good spellers.

- True
- False

2) When writing a college paper or an email to your coworker, you must be sure to get everything right on your first try.

- True
- False

3) Writing is a skill that can be improved through training and practice.

- True
- False

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4) If you don't learn proper grammar by the time you get to college, you'll never learn it.

- True
- False

5) Proper capitalization and punctuation are important as they make your writing more readable.

- True
- False

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6) Students who were not successful writers and received poor grades in their high school writing courses can expect to receive poor grades in college writing courses, too.

- True
- False

7) Writing is a process that should be taken one step at a time, not something that should be attempted all in one sitting.

- True
- False

4.2 Why Writing?

Why do we write? There are many reasons; but, at a basic level, we write because it is the best tool we have for communicating information.

Written words are powerful because they have the potential to reach so many people and spread information and knowledge far and wide. The thoughts and ideas of one mind can reach thousands of others. Writing and reading help us learn things and give us the opportunity to expand on our collective knowledge. There is an entire library of writing behind every subject and task.

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Writing makes it easier for businesses to function and for salespeople to communicate with customers. Potential employees write their way into jobs through cover letters, and established employees write letters for promotions or to ask for a raise. Many of us write to connect with friends and loved ones through email or social media or texts. Clear communication is the foundation for personal, academic, and professional connections.

The ways in which you express yourself and connect with others are the result of years of valuable life experience and the influence of the people around you—family, friends, communities, teachers, coworkers, and leaders. You will continue to be shaped by people and life experiences, and your language and ways of expressing yourself will continue to evolve. For example, at the university level, your instructors will give you the tools that you need to improve your writing and communication. As you study different subjects along your college journey, writing is the glue that holds and connects these subjects together.

You have a voice, and you are a writer. You have the power to communicate your ideas and contribute to the knowledge of others. As a student, you will write in discussion posts, worksheets, and, in some courses, longer assignments and papers. Now is the time to take your skillset and enhance it. Your journey continues here.

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The first sentence you should write in college is this: ***I have potential***. Take a second to jot that down on a piece of paper and try to remember that writing is not a skill that is learned overnight, but one that you will continue to develop over time.

As a new student, it's natural to feel some anxiety about writing. In this video, faculty member Brad Carroll gives you a great overview of what it takes to be a successful writer in college.

Figure 4.2.1: Overview of College Writing

Transcript

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Figure 4.2.2: Reflect on Your Learning

What is one thing you know that you want future generations of your family to know? What would you choose to write down?

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4.3 Considerations in College Writing

Audience and Tone

Imagine that someone asked you to write a few sentences about a single event that shaped your life, and you had to read those sentences to an audience that sat behind a curtain. Imagine you knew nothing about this audience. In this situation, you might feel nervous. Who might be sitting behind that curtain? What do they know? What do they value? What might be motivating them to listen to what you have to say? The less you know about who your readers are, the more difficult it may be to address them.

It can be helpful to get your thoughts on paper in a way that is only meant for you—such as a private journal—but most of the time, your writing is meant to be read. If words did not have readers, they would be less useful. Writers need an audience.

Your audience has a big effect on how you write, especially your tone. If you write to a boss or an instructor, you are likely to have a more professional or academic tone. This means you will be more likely to use formal language and less likely to rely on everyday conversational expressions (which, by the way, are not a bad thing; they simply have their place).

If you write to a friend, your tone is likely to be more casual. You might rely on expressions that are effective, but informal. For example, someone who expresses agreement in a formal environment might say, "This is a positive development." In a conversation with a friend, the phrase, "That's cool," could be a substitute. Each expression differs in tone, which is a way of referring to how a written word might "sound" to the reader.

As a person who lives life in different scenarios (home, school, and work), you must learn to put on the right communication "hat" at the right time. Your voice for your employer differs from how you might address your spouse, partner, or children. The small talk you have with your companions may not be appropriate for the office.

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In this course, and in many others, your audience will range from your instructor to your classmates. Your instructor and classmates will read your discussion posts, and your instructor will read your submitted assignments. As you proceed, think about how to write in a way that is helpful for your peers, and for your instructor. Be clear and polite, and also be willing to take risks and be wrong. It is ok to make an error. Use formal language to the best of your ability and express yourself. Be yourself.

Content and Clarity

Audience, content, and purpose are the "who," "what," and "why" of your communication. Now that we've looked at audience and purpose, let's focus on the content of your communication—in other words, what you want to say. You will be more effective in communicating with your audience when you have a clear idea about what to say and how to say it. As you approach each discussion question or assignment in your coursework, take time to consider the relevant and meaningful content you want to deliver, and how you want to write it so that it aligns with your audience and your purpose.

Understanding audience and purpose are critical to good writing, but that is only part of creating content that is successful at communicating your ideas. You must also deliver the content and message in a way that is understandable to the reader—that is, with clarity.

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Clarity in communication begins with arranging your thoughts in an orderly sequence. Some people use an outline to help create this order. Once you have a plan for the order in which you want to share your ideas, the next step in communicating with clarity is to consider the language and the words you use. Clarity depends on careful and intentional use of language. When you write, choose words and phrases with clear meaning, and craft sentences that are understandable to the reader.

To communicate with clarity, not only do your sentences need to be understandable, but they also need to work together. You want to lead your reader from one idea to the next in a way that allows them to follow your meaning and reasoning. It may be helpful for you to read your writing out loud to yourself or another person to check for understanding and clarity.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 4.3.1: Academic Tone and Clarity

1) Why is it important for a writer to be aware of their audience?

- It will guarantee the writer earns an "A" on the assignment.
- It helps the writer choose appropriate topics, themes, and vocabulary. It also helps set the overall tone.
- When a writer is aware of the audience, everyone in that audience will benefit from the essay.
- It makes it easier to check for errors in grammar, spelling, and punctuation.

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2) Select the example below that best demonstrates the use of formal tone.

- Hey! Paul!
  I heard you'll drop by after dinner.
  Sweet. Hit me up when you do.
- Dear Paul,
  I received your email last night. It is good to hear from you, and I am pleased to learn you will visit in the late afternoon.
  Regards,
  Jessica
- Paul,
  Where ya been? It's been forever lol. Call me. I'm hungry. We should grab some food.
- Paul i heard ur coming in later it is been 4ever since we last talked and I think we should catch up sound good hope to C U soon.

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3) Nikki missed a call and got a voicemail from one of her clients. Which of the following email responses to Nikki's customer is the most professional?

- Thank you for contacting me. I am sorry I could not get back to you right away. Please feel free to reach me at my office phone. You can contact me at my email address, as well.
- You missed me again! Yikes! I need to do a better job staying at my desk. Yikes. Just. Wow. Sorry about that.
- Thanks for calling, I'm sorry that, I could not get back too you write away. please feel free to call me. At my office phone. you can also, contact me at my email.
- LOL I WASN'T HERE WHEN YOU CALLED. THERE I GO AGAIN!

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4) Select the response that provides the most appropriate feedback to this message:

Yo! Mr. Smith! My quarterly review is low and I demand to know why; it's not fair I did everything that I was asked and I STILL got a bad score. I tried really hard and this is the thanks I get. I am discouraged and don't know why I should try. Thanx.

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- To improve this email, the only thing the writer needs to do is remove the slang and shorthand words, such as "Yo" and "Thanx."
- This email fits an academic or professional setting. Send away!
- This email should be revised so that it's more polite and approachable. The writer should also polish up the writing by correcting the run-on sentence, replacing "Thanx" and "Yo" with more appropriate words, and removing the "all caps" formatting.
- This email is too short. The writer should elaborate to improve the tone.

5) Which of the following emails would be the best one for Mary to send to her supervisor?

- Ms. Gilmore,

  Everyone else got a 5 percent raise and mine was only two and a half percent. What gives. Seriously.

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- Ms. Gilmore,

  I hope your day is going well. Recently, I have learned that my colleagues got a raise that is higher than mine. I believe my performance is strong, and I appreciate your leadership. I was wondering if I could learn why my performance did not earn a higher increase.
  Thank you in advance,

  Mary Smith

- I only got a small raise and don't get why.

- Ms. Gilmore,

  LOL there goes my performance incentive this year. WOW! I can only laugh at myself for this one. I am disappointed ha ha but whatever will be be.

  ~Mary

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Figure 4.3.1: Reflect on Your Learning

Think about popular blogs or websites or magazines that appeal to you. What is the purpose of these publications, and what is it that attracts you as a reader?

4.4 Approaching Assignments

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How to Approach Assignments

Have you ever taken a shortcut or neglected an important step in a task? While baking a cake, perhaps you didn't allow enough time for the cake to cool before icing it. Maybe you painted something without properly cleaning the surface first, and later the paint began to peel. Whatever the case, instructions are there to increase the

likelihood of achieving a goal and most people have seen the consequences of not following important steps and directions.

Consequences also exist for skipping steps during writing exercises. Someone who talks about the wrong topic in a discussion thread may lose points, confuse the class, or both. In a professional setting, a potential employer might ask for a 200-word cover letter, and a longer cover letter may result in the application getting dismissed from consideration.

In class, read the instructions thoroughly before beginning an assignment or discussion response. Ask your instructor if you have questions or need clarification on any part of the directions. Follow any steps, and double check that your responses meet each part of the instructions before you post or submit.

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Who Needs Instructions?

As you approach writing activities in this course, you may be nervous about what you want to say. Sometimes, even writing a handful of sentences in a discussion post can feel like a monumental task. If you have ever felt this way, or if you fear writer's block, remember that assignments and discussion questions often provide information and instructions that help you get started.

The instructions for writing exercises are written to guide you in what you need to say, keep you from drifting off topic, and ensure that your writing response is not too long or too short. When students have not completed an assignment as well as they could have, it is not uncommon for an instructor to notice the assignment has not complied with one or more important instructions.

When you review instructions as you prepare to start an assignment, consider the following questions:

- What is the due date for the writing exercise?
- Is there a required worksheet or other document where I should place my response?
- Is there a word count, and if so, is there any room to come under that count or go past it?
- Is it necessary that I provide examples or use sources to support my response?
- Is there a template or a sample assignment that can show me what is expected?

Formatting and Rubrics

Think about the last time you went to the grocery store. Were you able to find foods you wanted in the right categories or sections? Though we rarely think about how everyday items are organized, we often depend on others to organize items and tasks. Imagine if you went to the store, only to find products were not organized by any principle at all. Making your way through that kind of scene would be frustrating. If dairy products were mixed with the produce, or if canned goods were stored with paper towels and toilet paper, shoppers would become confused and frustrated, and would probably leave without everything on their lists.

Trips to the store are made easier because there is form, or shape, and purpose to the way that the store is laid out. Things are in the right places for good reasons.

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When you approach writing exercises in college, you may be asked to follow a model. It might be simple, such as a worksheet where the answers should go in boxes or blank spaces. In some courses, you will be tasked with writing exercises that ask you to follow APA formatting (which provides rules for things like creating title pages, giving credit to sources, and spacing your paragraphs). When a piece of writing is formatted correctly, it is more welcoming to the readers.

Finally, many of your writing assignments will be graded based on a rubric. A rubric, which is usually in the form of a chart, contains the requirements and expectations for an assignment. Rubrics also indicate the percentage of points associated with each of those requirements.

If you feel disconnected or confused when it comes to assignment expectations, check to see if there is a rubric. The rubric can provide you with the guidance you need to meet assignment expectations; this can be especially helpful for writing assignments. Remember, if you ever have a question about assignment instructions or a rubric, reach out to your instructor.

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Figure 4.4.1: Sample Assignment Rubric

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Wk 3 - College Communication Worksheet [due M...

Rubric Details

Maximum Score	180 points

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Part 1: Describe an Effective Comm...

30% of total grade

Accomplished
The student clearly described an approach to solve the problem, including the first contact and available resources. The student clearly outlined why effective communication was important to the problem-solving process.
90 - 100%

Emerging
The student partially described an approach to solve the problem, including the first contact and available resources. The student partially outlined why effective communication was important to the problem-solving process.
70 - 89%

Beginning
The student vaguely described an approach to solve the problem and may have omitted first contact and/or available resources. The student vaguely outlined why effective communication was important to the problem-solving process.
50 - 69%

Not Evident
A description of an effective approach to the problem was not provided.
0 - 0%

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Building Writing Confidence

As mentioned before, writing skills are developed over time. You will continue developing your skills and building confidence in your writing as you move through this class and all the other classes in your program.

When you feel challenged by a writing assignment, remember to visit the Center for Writing Excellence (CWE). The CWE has numerous resources that can help you with your writing skills and with meeting assignment requirements. Students find the Guidelines for Writing Academic Essays section especially helpful when they have to complete a writing assignment.

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4.5 The Writing Process

Like any complex task, a writing assignment becomes less intimidating when approached as a process that can be broken into steps that can be taken one at a time. Students who wait to get to work until the night before an assignment is due are putting themselves through unnecessary stress. Whether you're writing a paper for a class or a presentation at work, getting an early start is key to success because it allows you to step through the writing process instead of taking one giant leap.

Figure 4.5.1: Steps in the Writing Process

Step 1: Prewriting

The minute you start thinking about your paper, the writing process has begun. Prewriting is the thinking you do before organizing and drafting a paper. For college papers, it involves selecting a topic and coming up with ideas for it. Prewriting is also worthwhile for workplace writing projects. If you are tasked with writing a report, a set of instructions, or even an important email, it's a good idea to put some thought into it before beginning to write.

For your University of Phoenix writing assignments, you will likely be presented with a list of pre-approved topics for papers. Be sure to look at assignment guidelines early in the week to start your prewriting. Consider the topic choices and choose the one for which you can come up with the best ideas.

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Figure 4.5.2: Common Strategies for Prewriting

Brainstorming

If you don't do your best thinking while sitting down, get up and take a walk, or think about your topic while doing housework, sitting in a waiting room, riding on a bus---anything you do that doesn't require your complete concentration. If you worry about forgetting your ideas, jot them down or use a voice-recording or note-taking app to capture them.

Freewriting

Just as it sounds, freewriting is to write freely, capturing all your thoughts as they come to you without judging them or yourself. If some of your ideas sound silly, don't worry about that, and don't try to fix errors as you make them. Just keep writing, whether you're scribbling on a piece of paper or typing on a computer.

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Mind Mapping

If you like to doodle, mind mapping might be a good option for you. Draw a circle on a piece of paper and write your topic inside of it, then draw several lines coming out of that circle. At the end of each line, write down an idea related to your topic, and draw a circle around it. Keep going until you've run out of ideas.

No matter what methods you choose to use while prewriting, it's better to come up with too many ideas rather than too few. You can always weed out the weaker ones in the next step in the writing process: organization.

Step 2: Organization

Now that you have ideas for your writing assignment, it is time to organize them. You don't have to write a formal outline, but you will need a plan for your paper. A standard structure for a college essay begins with an introduction, which is followed by a body paragraph for each main point, and ends with a concluding paragraph that summarizes the main points and conclusions.

Let's imagine that you have an assignment to write a paper about the benefits of a University of Phoenix education. You've done all the prewriting for that topic and have decided that the two most important benefits of a college education are that it helps students achieve their personal goals and it improves their prospects for professional success.

A basic topic outline for this paper might look like this:

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- Introduction
- Personal Goals
- Professional Success
- Conclusion

If you choose to write an outline in complete sentences, your thesis statement would serve as your introduction, each main point would be a topic sentence of a body paragraph, and your conclusion would restate your thesis statement, without repeating it word-for-word.

A basic sentence outline for your imaginary paper on the benefits of a University of Phoenix education might look like this:

- Introduction: A University of Phoenix education helps students meet their personal goals and achieve professional success.
- Paragraph 1: The critical thinking skills developed in the online classroom help students meet their personal goals.
- Paragraph 2: Earning a college degree offers students better opportunities for professional success.
- Conclusion: The personal and professional benefits of a University of Phoenix education make it worth the time and effort required.

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You don't have to write an outline in sentence form, but doing so would give you a head start on the next step in the writing process: drafting.

Step 3: Drafting

Once you have decided on your topic, your main points, and the order in which you will cover those points, you can sit down and draft your paper. Drafting is writing in complete sentences and in paragraph form, and the first attempt at doing this is considered a rough draft. It's called "rough" because it's not expected to be perfect. The first version of a paper won't be perfect, which is why it is important to allow yourself enough time to write a rough draft and revise it before submitting it as a final paper. Do this for all writing projects to get the best results.

When you are writing your rough draft, don't try to correct errors. Just get all of your thoughts onto the paper (or screen). Bear in mind that you don't have to draft the three basic parts of a paper—the Introduction, Body, and Conclusion—in that particular order. For example, you might choose to write the body of your paper before you write your introduction.

When your rough draft is complete, take a break from it. If you've managed your time well, set the draft aside for a day or so. If you're short on time, give yourself at least an hour to refresh your brain before taking the next step in the writing process: revision.

Step 4: Revising

To revise is to change for the better. With writing, that means adding, deleting, or moving text to improve a draft. A good way to begin revising is to read your rough draft once without making any changes. Be kind to yourself! Most writers are disappointed when they read their rough drafts. Trust that you can make it better.

Next, read through it again, making changes as you see fit. Add transitions, such as "however" or "on the other hand," to connect your sentences and ideas. Delete or remove what doesn't work or fit and replace it with something better. Swap vague words and phrases with more specific ones. Add details. You might find that you need to rearrange parts of your paper by cutting and pasting. Don't be afraid to make drastic changes when you revise. Make it the paper you want it to be.

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All this adding, cutting, and pasting will lead to errors, which is why it is important to take the final step in the writing process: editing.

Step 5: Editing

Editing is finding and fixing errors in your writing, ensuring that you produce a clean, readable piece of work. Careful editing will likely improve your grades on papers, but it is also critically important with employment writing. A careless error in a resume or cover letter could cost you a job opportunity.

Fortunately, there are tools to help with editing, and you should make use of them. Microsoft® Word's grammar and style checking tools can identify errors such as commonly confused words and missing punctuation. Grammarly.com offers a free grammar and spell check application that will help you edit on your smartphone as well as on your computer.

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Editing and proofreading tools won't catch every error, though, so be sure to read your draft carefully, looking for misspellings, typos, missing words, and other problems. You might try reading your paper one word at a time or reading it backwards. Our brains tend to overlook errors in our own writing when reading it in the traditional way, from start to finish. Reading backwards forces us to slow down and examine each word. Look not only for mechanical errors, but also for unnecessary words or phrases. Having another set of eyes to examine your work can be beneficial, so, if you can, enlist a volunteer to help with editing.

Now that you've taken that final step and edited your paper, you can feel proud of the work you have done. If you approach every writing assignment by budgeting your time and taking each step in the writing process—prewriting, organizing, drafting, revising, and editing—you will not only be successful in your courses, but you will also improve your writing skills, which will benefit your life and career.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 4.5.1: The Writing Process

1) Which of these statements is true?

- Approaching writing as a process stifles creativity.
- The steps in the writing process are prewriting, organizing, drafting, revising, and editing.

2) Maria has an essay due at the end of the week for her ENG/100 class. She reads the assignment instructions on the first day of the week, selects a topic, and starts thinking about it. Which step in the writing process has she taken?

- Organizing
- Prewriting

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3) Donovan was asked by his boss to evaluate three software packages and make a recommendation to the Purchasing Manager about which would be best for their office. He is

putting together a slide presentation and decides to present what he thinks is the best choice last. What organizational method is Donovan using?

- Chronological Order
- Order of Importance

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4) Jose has been asked to write a set of procedures at work, and he has already created a draft and made some changes to it. Before emailing the file to his boss, he runs spell-check on it and reads it carefully, looking for mistakes. Which step in the writing process is Jose taking?

- Editing
- Revising

4.6 Communicating in the Virtual Environment

Classroom Communication

If you open a job search engine such as Indeed.com and search for the job you would like to have in five years, you will likely see "strong communication skills" listed in the job description. If you're worried that you don't have this qualification, trust that you can build it through your college education. A skill is an ability that can be improved through training and practice. Your University of Phoenix courses and instructors will provide the training, and the work you do in those courses will give you the practice needed to strengthen your communication skills and make you a more desirable candidate for jobs and promotions. Your writing practice in the classroom may also help you to communicate more effectively in your personal life. For example, you may need to handle a legal matter or write an effective email to your child's teacher. Developing strong communication skills will benefit you personally and professionally.

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For many students, texting and social media are their primary forms of written communication. The online classroom gives an opportunity to break habits formed while texting, tweeting, and posting, and establish new, more professional writing habits. While ideas are typically more important than how they are presented, a professional approach will help communicate those ideas more effectively. Just as you would dress appropriately for a job interview, you should dress your writing appropriately for the online classroom. Make it presentable! It doesn't have to be overly formal; think casual but not sloppy—like a casual Friday at work, where polo shirts and jeans are permitted, but tank tops and ripped shorts with the pockets hanging out are not.

Email Etiquette

Emails are a very common type of written communication in the workplace, and the ability to write effective ones can advance your career, so it's good idea to practice proper email writing form as a student.

Tips for proper email etiquette:

- Use a salutation, which is a fancy word for a greeting. “Hi, Professor Carroll” followed by a comma will work for an instructor; for employment writing, go with “Dear Brad” followed by a comma.
- Write in paragraph form if you need more than one paragraph.
- Follow a business writing format with block paragraphs and text aligned on the left side of the page.
- Proofread for spelling and capitalization errors.
- End with a closing and signature. There are many to choose from, and you should, again, consider your audience. “Sincerely” sounds a little stuffy if addressing a fellow student, or even an instructor, but it would work for a letter inquiring about a job opportunity.
- Don’t use “all caps” text, which can be perceived as shouting at your reader.
- Don’t use all italics because that can be hard to read.

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With emails, as with any other type of writing, try to write clearly and concisely, and consider your audience. When writing an email at work, you should consider that the entire company could end up being your audience. What you send to a coworker might be seen by your boss, your boss’s boss, and so forth. Practice being professional in the classroom, so that your professionalism will shine through in the workplace and light the way to better opportunities.

Contacting Your Instructor

Your instructor will provide their contact information in each course, including an email address and telephone number, but the best way to get an answer to a question is to send a private message through the online classroom in Blackboard. To access private messages within the classroom, simply click on the envelope icon at the top of your class in Blackboard.

Remember, your private message is going right to your instructor, so messages should be polite in tone, capitalized properly, and proofed for spelling errors. Ensuring your messages are well-written will give you practice developing professional writing habits. It’s fine to call your instructor by his or her first name, unless they have indicated otherwise. If you ask for help with an assignment, make sure you have first read the assignment instructions, then ask a specific question. Don’t just state that you are having trouble with an assignment. Describe your problem in detail so your instructor can better assist you.

Private messages are not just for asking questions. You should also reach out to your instructor in the event that you will be submitting an assignment late if, for example, you are ill or are having internet connectivity issues. University of Phoenix instructors are understanding people, so be sure to let them know before the assignment is due if you are having difficulties completing an assignment because of challenging circumstances.

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When sending a private message, check the box to send an email notification to ensure your instructor sees the message as soon as possible. Additionally, be sure to check your private messages regularly as well, as your instructor might be trying to get in touch with you about an assignment or with their own questions. For instance, if you submit a file incorrectly, your instructor may send you a private message asking you to resubmit your file. If you don’t check your messages, you might end up with a zero on the assignment.

Follow the steps below to set up your Blackboard profile to notify you of new private messages:

- **Click** on the Blackboard toolbar (the black strip on the left side of your computer screen).
- **Click** on your name.
- **Look** for Global Notifications Settings under System Settings and click on SMS Notifications if you wish to be notified by text, and Email Notifications if you wish to be notified by email. (You may choose one or both.)
- **Check** the box for New Messages.
- **Click** on Save.

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You can visit the Classroom Resource Center to learn more about navigating and communicating in Blackboard.

Discussion Participation

One of the pillars of the University of Phoenix online classroom experience is participating in weekly discussion with your classmates. You've been doing this for a few weeks now. Although responding to discussion questions and the comments made by your classmates can seem overwhelming at times, classroom discussions are an opportunity to practice your communication skills. Each week, you will respond to discussion questions and reply to your classmates and instructor. Below are some tips to keep in mind when crafting appropriate responses.

General tips for classroom posts:

- Write complete sentences with a capital letter at the beginning of each sentence and correct punctuation.
- Keep it simple. You don't have to try to impress anyone, and your posts don't have to be perfect. Each discussion post is an attempt to communicate and connect with others.
- Capitalize your classmates' names if you address them, and always capitalize the pronoun *I*.
- Proofread your posts. Your spelling and punctuation do not have to be perfect, but you should try to fix errors before posting.
- Aim for a formal tone. Avoid acronyms and casual misspellings such as *gonna, wanna, thru*, and *u*. Avoid writing posts that look like casual text messages.

Tips for discussion responses:

- Answer each of the questions asked. Reading the course materials will help you do this.
- Meet the word count requirement. Word count requirements may vary from class to class, so read the discussion instructions carefully to determine the required length for responses.
- Write in paragraph form, breaking for a new paragraph when you move from answering one question to another.

Tips for replies:

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- Be mindful of your tone, which should be respectful. While you may disagree with a point your classmate has made in one of your replies, you should do so politely.
- Be specific and thoughtful. Don't simply agree; state why you agree and provide an example.
- Share personal experiences. This will add interest to your replies and help you connect with your classmates.
- Asking questions is an excellent way to engage with your classmates and keep the discussion going in the classroom.

4.7 Academic Integrity

Writing with Integrity

Right now, you might be wondering what academic integrity is, why it's important, and what it has to do with this week's topic of communication. At its core, academic integrity is about honesty and trust. It requires you, as a writer, to give proper credit for ideas you use in your assignments, and it requires you to approach your studies in a responsible manner. Demonstrating academic integrity adds value to your degree and shows you are a student worthy of trust. The University of Phoenix requires students to adhere to the ethical standards necessary to maintain individual and institutional academic integrity. As members of the University's academic community, students acknowledge and accept a responsibility to abide by the Student Code of Conduct, which includes the Student Code of Academic Integrity.

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Introduction to Plagiarism

A common instance of violating academic integrity is committing plagiarism. Plagiarism is presenting someone else's ideas as your own, meaning you don't give credit to the original author or presenter. Whether accidental or intentional, plagiarism is a serious violation of the Student Code of Conduct and carries significant consequences. Understanding what plagiarism is will help you create original work without worrying about possible penalties. Watch the following video for an introduction to plagiarism.

Figure 4.7.1: Perils of Plagiarism

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Transcript

Examples of Plagiarism

Plagiarism can be accidental or intentional, but it's important to remember that the consequences are the same either way. It is the student's responsibility to check their work carefully to ensure that all direct quotations and ideas that are not original are correctly cited and referenced.

Below are some examples of plagiarism, several of which could occur accidentally as well as intentionally.

Example 1: Writing material very close to the original by replacing a few words with synonyms. This is one of the most frequent types of plagiarism—accidental or intentional.

Example 2: Omitting quotation marks when using a direct quotation from another source.

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Example 3: Omitting a citation for a direct quotation or information paraphrased from a source.

Example 4: Copying and pasting a source from the internet without using quotation marks or citations.

Example 5: Using vague or incorrect citations, such that a reader could not locate the source.

Example 6: Using another student's work as your own.

Example 7: Purchasing an essay from a website or using an essay from a free website as your own assignment.

Example 8: Reusing your work from another class or assignment without properly citing the original work and getting approval from your instructor.

Preventing Plagiarism

Two of the most common causes of plagiarism are omitting citations for information obtained from a source and omitting quotation marks for a direct quotation. These issues can be a result of students not allowing enough time to complete an assignment. Sometimes students find it easier to plagiarize than to follow the correct steps to create an effective written assignment. There are entire guides that can provide details about giving credit, but for now, some basic steps can help you uphold academic integrity. See the rules below for steps you can take to prevent plagiarism.

Rule 1: Include a citation for ideas that are not your own and are not common knowledge, even if you have paraphrased and your words are different from those in the source.

Rule 2: Use quotation marks and a citation with a page or paragraph number to acknowledge when you have used a direct quotation of words or phrases from another source.

Rule 3: Avoid using too many direct quotations, even if you include citations. The bulk of the paper should contain your original ideas supported by information from sources. To avoid plagiarism, check with your instructor for guidelines about the length and number of direct quotations that should be used in a paper.

Avoiding Accidental Plagiarism

Plagiarism, whether accidental or intentional, usually begins at the note taking stage of the writing process. If information is plagiarized in your notes, it can easily be transferred into plagiarized material in your final paper. You can eliminate accidental plagiarism by taking careful notes and giving credit for other people's words and ideas, statistical information, graphics, or drawings. You can eliminate intentional plagiarism by being ethical and honest and allowing enough time to research and write an assignment.

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Use the following tips to eliminate plagiarism while taking notes and writing papers:

Taking Notes

- Allow time for research.
- Capture all information from the source to use in the reference list citations within.
- Include the name of the source and page or paragraph numbers so you won't need to return to the source later to locate a missing page number, etc.
- Write down in your own words the information you want to use from the source as you take notes.
- Copy words directly from the source *only* if you want to quote the passage in the paper.
- Use quotation marks for direct quotations and anything copied directly from a source and include page numbers of the quotations in your notes.

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Writing Papers

- Allow time for writing.
- Write your own ideas for your assignment and use source material to support those ideas.
- Write from your notes rather than from the original source, and paraphrase.
- Use quotation marks to indicate anything that is a direct quotation from a source.
- Include citations as you are writing instead of going back to fill them in when the paper is finished.
- Check the source to be sure direct quotations have been copied accurately.
- Check the source to be sure page or paragraph numbers are correct

Learn More About Plagiarism

The thought of committing unintentional plagiarism can cause some students anxiety. Students want to produce quality work that meets the University of Phoenix's standards for academic honesty. Much like other aspects of writing, giving proper credit to source material is a skill. Luckily, there are quite a few resources in the Center for Writing Excellence (CWE) that can help you develop that skill. Check out the Plagiarism Tutorial in the CWE and the Plagiarism guide available from the American Psychological Association to learn more about avoiding plagiarism.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 4.7.1: Plagiarism

1) Which of the following statements provides the best definition for the term *plagiarism*?

- Plagiarism occurs only when you use the exact words of another and pass them off as your own.
- Plagiarism includes all types of dishonesty in an academic setting. For example, passing off the words or ideas of another as your own, or including fake data.

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- Plagiarism refers to the act of using material from another source as your own without giving proper credit to the original source. This includes direct quotations, paraphrased material, charts, graphs, and images. It's also possible to commit self-plagiarism by reusing work from previous classes or assignments without properly citing the original work.

- Plagiarism is when an author cites a source but doesn't include the year of publication or the page number in their citation.

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2) Which of the following statements best describes the consequences of plagiarism?

- Plagiarism is not acceptable, but it's only considered a minor academic offense so there are no serious consequences.

- When someone commits plagiarism, they cheat themselves out of a valuable learning experience.

- Students who don't know what plagiarism is in the first place won't get in trouble if they commit it.

- Plagiarism is a term that applies only to students in an academic setting.

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3) Which of the following scenarios most accurately demonstrates an act of plagiarism?

- Sue included a direct quotation from an article in an essay she recently wrote. She placed quotation marks around the entire quotation and included the year of publication and page number after the quotation. She did not, however, include the name of the original author.

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- Gary submitted a short paper that included direct quotations in nearly every sentence. For each quotation, he used quotation marks and included the name of the author, year of publication, and page number in his citations.

- Jason read an argument about why parents should vaccinate their kids. He wrote down the argument in his own words and to the best of his ability. He did not point to his source material in his text or use any in-text citations or reference page citations.

- Rebekah included a quotation from an article in a paper she recently submitted. She included the author's full name, opened the quotation with a quotation mark, and placed a citation after the quotation was over. However, she forgot to include the closing quotation mark.

4) Regina has an essay due in two days. According to the assignment instructions, she must include at least two sources from the University Library to support her ideas. How would you recommend Regina address this challenge?

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- Ignore the assignment requirements and write the essay based on what she already knows about the topic.
- Just copy and paste content from a reliable website.
- Obtain a copy of the essay from a friend who completed the same course three months earlier and submit it as her own.
- Review the resources in the Center for Writing Excellence (CWE) for guidelines on the proper use of direct quotations, paraphrasing, and summarizing outside sources in an essay.

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5) It's 5:00 p.m. on Monday and Marcus's assignment is due in a few hours. He read a few articles about the assignment topic during lunch and feels confident that he knows enough about the topic to write his paper. He wants to include a direct quotation from one of the articles that really resonated with him, but he can't remember where he found the quotation or how to properly cite it. What could Marcus have done differently to avoid this situation?

- Take notes on the information about the articles he read and what was covered in each.
- Review the resources in the Center for Writing Excellence (CWE) for properly including direct quotations in your writing.
- Create a plan for completing the assignment that allows enough time to complete the writing process.
- All of the above.

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Forms of Academic Dishonesty

Although plagiarism is the most common type of academic dishonesty, there are other ways of not upholding integrity in your work. According to the University of Phoenix's Student Code of Academic Integrity, other forms of academic dishonesty include:

- **Cheating**: Any attempt by a student to gain an unfair academic advantage by means other than their own knowledge. This includes, but is not limited to:
    - Assisting another student to plagiarize, copy, or observe one's own work. This includes submission of work to third parties that sell or provide free of charge academic papers or assignments, regardless of how the third party describes their mission, purpose, or materials.
    - Using the textbook, manuals, electronic devices, or other materials in a manner not authorized by faculty or the University.
    - Allowing another person, whether free of charge or for hire, to complete work on one's behalf, including any classroom post, assignment, quiz, test, exam, or similar evaluation, or doing the same in place of another person.
    - Providing or requesting assistance from another person in a manner not authorized in writing by faculty.
- **Fabrication or Falsification**: Falsification or invention of any information, citation, data, or document. This includes the invention or alteration of data or results or relying on another source's results in any assignment without proper acknowledgement of that source. Fabrication includes citing sources that the student has not actually used or consulted.
- **Self-Plagiarism, Double-Dipping, or Dovetailing**: Submitting one's own academic work that is identical or substantially similar to one's own work previously submitted, unless specifically authorized by the course faculty or course curriculum.

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Tutoring Sites in Disguise

Some websites market themselves as being "study resources," "tutoring sites," or "academic assistance," however, the content they provide may lead students to violate the University's Student Code of Academic Integrity. These sites often require payment or an uploaded assignment from you in return for access to other students' assignments and other course materials. Submission of any materials that are not your own is considered academic misconduct. Do not do this! Additionally, when you upload other University-created documents, like worksheets or syllabi, to these sites, you can be in violation of copyright regulations leading to sanctions that include a failing grade in the course, suspension, expulsion, or degree revocation.

The University uses SafeAssign as one way to detect academic misconduct. SafeAssign compares assignment submissions with previously submitted assignments, academic papers, and other content from internet sources. It provides faculty members, students, and the University with a report that matches assignment contents to unoriginal content without attribution.

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Your textbook, the University Library, and your faculty member are your best points of reference when researching your assignments. If you are searching for a tutor, reach out to your Academic Counselor since the University does provide tutoring resources for various courses.

Student Code of Conduct

The Student Code of Conduct of University of Phoenix supports the University's mission to provide access to higher education opportunities that enable students to develop the knowledge and skills necessary to achieve their professional goals, improve the performance of their organizations, and provide leadership and service to their communities.

Students are expected to conduct themselves ethically, honestly, and with integrity as responsible members of the University's academic community. This requires the demonstration of mutual respect and civility in academic and professional discourse. A University is a marketplace of ideas and, in the search for truth, it is essential that opportunity exists for contrary ideas to be expressed. Accordingly, students are expected to respect the rights and privileges of others and to foster an environment conducive to learning. Students are accountable for their actions and are required to work independently, as well as collaboratively with teams, to achieve learning goals and objectives.

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By virtue of membership in the University's academic community, students accept an obligation to abide by this Student Code of Conduct. Conduct, either on or off campus, that is determined to impair, interfere with, or obstruct the opportunities of others to learn or that disrupts the mission, processes, or orderly functions of the University will be deemed misconduct and shall be subject to appropriate disciplinary action.

Misconduct for which students are subject to disciplinary action includes, but is not limited to, the following violations:

1. Actions, oral statements, and written statements which threaten or violate the personal safety of any member of the faculty, staff, or other students.
2. Harassment that has the effect of creating a hostile or offensive educational environment for any student, faculty, or staff member.
3. Sex discrimination/sexual harassment that has the effect of creating a hostile or offensive educational environment for any student, faculty, or staff member. This includes, but is not limited to, sex discrimination, sexual harassment, unwelcome conduct of a sexual nature, unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and other verbal and nonverbal, or physical conduct of a sexual nature including sexual violence.
4. Stalking or persistently pursuing another person that has the effect of imposing unwelcomed contact and/or communication.
5. Disruptive behavior that hinders or interferes with the educational process.
6. Violation of any applicable professional codes of ethics or conduct.
7. Failure to promptly comply with any reasonable directive from faculty or University officials.
8. Failure to cooperate in a University investigation.
9. Carrying of weapons on campus, at campus-sanctioned events, or when meeting with campus personnel. (This policy is not applicable to students who are law enforcement officers required by law to carry firearms at all times).
10. Using, dealing in, or being under the influence of alcohol or illegal drugs while in class, at campus-sanctioned events, or when meeting with campus personnel.
11. Failure to maintain confidentiality and respect the privacy of personal or professional information communicated about clients, one's employer, other students or their employers.
12. Falsification, alteration or invention of information, including, but not limited to, any third party document used to apply for financial aid, or lying during a University investigation.
13. Violation of the Student Code of Academic Integrity.
14. Violation of the policy on Acceptable Use of University Computing and Communication Resources for Students and Faculty.

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15. Hazing (any action which recklessly or intentionally endangers the mental health or physical health or safety of a student for the purpose of initiation or admission into or affiliation with any University-sanctioned organization).
16. Violation of University regulations and policies (in addition to those regulations and policies covered by items 1-15 above).
17. Violation of federal, state, or local laws or regulations that impacts the University's educational environment.

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You can learn more about your student rights and responsibilities as well as the consequences for not complying to the code, by reviewing the University of Phoenix's comprehensive Code of Student Conduct.

4.8 References

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TED (2013, May 9). *Angela Lee Duckworth: The power of passion and perseverance* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?time_continue=14&v=H14bBuluwB8&feature=emb_logo

*****YOU HAVE NOW COMPLETED ALL OF THE READINGS FOR WEEK 3*****

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